Sympathy Over Polarization: A Computational Discourse Analysis of Trump's 2025 Policies

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***Abstract*—This work examines public opinion towards Donald Trump's policy proposals for 2025 ranging from immigration, LGBTQ+ rights to trade tariffs and ICE raids—through the use of computational discourse analysis on Reddit postings. Web scraping was utilized in conjunction with sentiment classification using RoBERTa, topic modeling using LDA, and Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA), to understand to what extent online discourse reflects polarization or sympathy. Findings indicate that the topics of ICE raids and LGBTQ+ are overwhelmingly negative in sentiment, whereas tariff and citizenship discourses veer towards even sentiment. Positive sentiment occurs low in all topics, as evidence of the critical and polarized nature of political discourse on the internet.**

***Index Terms*—Topic Modeling, ABSA, Sentiment Analysis Using RoBERTa.**

I. Introduction

The rise of social media has changed the nature of political debate in contemporary society. Platforms that facilitate users to engage in intense and typically unmediated argumentation like Reddit have become central locations for the capture of public opinion on major political decisions and policies. With the re-election of Donald Trump to the presidency in 2025, controversy laden policy revisions reignited national controversies about enforcement of the borders, rights for the LGBTQ+ population, tariffs, and birthright citizenship. These controversies are not only mediated through traditional media but also played out in real-time in virtual communities in which polarization and empathy appear. New computational techniques in the form of natural language processing (NLP) and machine learning offer new tools through which to study these enormous virtual conversations that provide evidence of how the public comprehends the government.

A. Statement of the Problem

While the use of social media to express political views has upsurged in recent times, little structured analysis has so far gone in to assess the public mood towards Trump's policy reforms in 2025.

Online discourse is not only polarised but also includes moments of cross-party sympathies.

Sentiment also varies for the subjects of ICE raids, LGBTQ+ rights, trade tariffs, and citizenship.

This project will answer these questions through the application of large-scale computational discourse analysis to Reddit data using the techniques of topic modeling, sentiment classification, and aspect-based sentiment analysis in order to track the trends in public reaction.

The results should shed light on the overall trends in the online political discourse and how digital communities both process and respond to controversial government policy.

II. Review of Literature

This section summarizes the currently available research to serve as the foundation for our study

- Zeng and colleagues (2025) conducted a cross-party response sentiment analysis following a bid on the life of Trump. They found that political high-risk incidents lower polarization in the short run because even ostensibly opposite sides reflected sympathetic responses. This study suggests that political rhetoric need not necessarily remain constant but can change radically in given situations [1].
- Holliday et al. (2024) examined reactions to political trauma in online spaces and found that major crises increase social unity and decrease partisan animosity.

Their study uncovers that even in the most polarized environments, collective trauma creates situational unity that crosses conflict boundaries, so context needs to be taken into consideration when analyzing sentiment [2].

- Mahowald et al. (2024) examined the biases in language models, observing that machine-learning technologies are prone to inadvertently reflect and even amplify the bias of society. This serves as a reminder for studies of this kind presented here, whereby computational models are being used to label sentiment, the need for caution and checking [3].
- Ostrom and Simon's 1985 work proffered a seminal theoretical overview of collective political conduct and the building and representation of political identity in discourse. Their work remains valuable today as an admonishment to scholars to look not to the surface appearances but to the underlying affective and ideological currents that shape political conversation. Combined these works demonstrate that public opinion is both context-dependent and dynamic and the result of both internal biases and external circumstances. They also emphasize the importance of using computational tools critically and of understanding both their potential and their limitations [1]–[3].
- Tan et al.'s (2018) extensive survey of deep transfer learning discusses its theoretical background, typical methods (e.g., instance-based, feature-based, and parameter-based methods), and applications to real-world tasks at length. The survey focuses on how transfer learning allows models to generalize across domain when there is limited labeled data, which is highly applicable to social media analysis with domain shift and sparsity present. Their classification of different methods for transfer learning provides a helpful basis for choosing and designing models for applications involving cross-platform sentiment analysis or multi-lingual NLP [4].
- Fariello and Jemielniak (2025) analyze longitudinal language and climate change-related sentiment from sixteen years of Reddit posts. Their research illustrates the shift over time within public discussions on climate issues in terms of affective tone and lexical selection, showing changes in society's attitudes and concerns. Through the use of computational sentiment analysis and topic modeling, the article illustrates the ever-changing nature of opinion online and produces evidence of politicization and polarization of environmental debate. The research emphasizes the value of large-scale, time-sensitive analysis for the assessment of extended-term patterns of online public opinion [5].
- Kumar and Sadanandam (2023) suggest a new architecture that fuses BERT and RoBERTa to enhance sentiment classification on twitter and other social networks. These two transformer-based encoders are leveraged for their respective strengths under their fusion model, which achieves higher accuracy and stability across noisy, crowdsourced text datasets. By comparing their model to traditional baselines, the authors demonstrate that ensemble methodologies of this kind may surpass those of individual models for difficult, applied NLP tasks. This method is especially helpful for applications like Reddit and twitter, where context sensitivity and language heterogeneity make traditional models difficult to use [6].

III. Objectives of the Study

- Analyze the mood of the public on Trump's 2025 stances on four key aspects: **Birth Right Citizenship, LGBTQ+ rights, Tariffs, and ICE raids.**
- Categorize the sentiment as positive, negative or neutral and track topic-specific trends.
- Investigate whether digital dialogue records patterns of polarization or moments of empathy.
- Identify the major discussion themes using topic modeling.
- Implement Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis to establish the sentiment for individual policy aspects.

IV. Data Collection

To accomplish this project work, we scrapped Reddit for post and comment threads related to Trump's 2025 policy reforms. We used Python scripts to scrape data in bulk in a structured way under four general themes of ICE raids, LGBTQ rights, trade tariffs, and birthright citizenship using the public API of Reddit through tools such as PRAW. Ethical scraping was ensured by not violating Reddit's API rate limit and scrapping only publicly accessible information that is not private in nature. During the scraping process

- **API Access** - Authentication of the request to the API and query limit management.
- **Keyword Filtering** - Using specific keywords (like "Trump ICE 2025," "Trump LGBTQ+ policy 2025") for selecting the applicable postings
- **Data Consolidation** - Extracting structured data that resides in the post data and the comment data and text data.
- **Data Storage** - Storing data in a .csv format to enable usage in Python analysis pipelines.

Dataset-https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1BgCHnVptk6bTvpNR24w8KZuQ4MZryVsi?role=writer

A. Data Description

Each data set includes the following columns:

- post_id- The Reddit post or comment's unique identifier.
- author- user name (pseudoonymized) of the poster or commenter
- body- The complete textual content of the Reddit post or comment.
- created_utc- The UTC timestamp when the post or the comment was made.
- subreddit- The subreddit in which the post or the comment was made.
- score- The upvote count for the post or comment minus the downvote count.

- topic_label- Topic category that has been assigned to the data to provide the framework for the information.

These columns gave us textual as well as context information so that not only did we consider sentiment but also patterns of engagement across a variety of topics.

B. Data Cleaning

Prior to analysis, we carried out stringent data cleansing to attain data consistency and quality.

- Missing value handling: We have removed records that have missing or null body fields to work only with relevant text in the analysis.
- Duplicate Removal: In addition to that, we searched for duplicate post_ids and deleted duplicates to not double count in topic or sentiment models.
- Text Pre-processing: we removed the URLs, emojis, user mentions, and HTML tags. Tokenization was performed to split the comments into individual words. Lemmatization was employed to convert the words to their base form. These have both a negative and positive impact on the sentences.
- Label Identification: As the datasets were already split by topic while scraping, the topic_label was already correct for each record depending on the source file (all records in reddit_comments_ICE.csv have a label of 'ICE', for instance). There was no need for a separate step for label verification.

V. Exploratory Data Analysis

- Data Profiling- We reviewed the quantity of posts by topic. The distribution of post lengths (word counts). Up-voting scores and engagement metrics. Temporal patterns (date of posting and time of day). This gave us a baseline understanding of the data volume, nature, and levels of user engagement in the four topic datasets.
- Topic Modeling- We ran Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) on each corpus in order to reveal hidden thematic patterns. LDA assigns words to topics based on the frequency of their co-occurrence in documents (in this instance, Reddit posts), assisting us in the identification of underlying themes in public conversation.
- Coherence Scores- In order to make sure that our LDA topics made sense and were interpretable, we computed coherence scores. A coherence score indicates the semantic similarity of highly scoring words within a topic, essentially, how well the words "stick together" semantically. We utilized the gensim library in Python, which offers:
- c_v coherence: With a window-based approach relying on a one-set partition and an indirect confirmation metric involving the use of normalized pointwise mutual information and cosine similarity.
- UMass coherence: In accordance to document co-occurrence frequency.
- C_uci and c_npmi: Word co-occurrence variants for normalized and raw. To determine coherence
  - We have trained LDA models for different numbers of topics (for example, 3-10).
  - We calculated the coherence score for each model.
  - We chose the configuration having the largest coherence score as the most optimal.

  This made the results of LDA not only mathematically sound but also human-interpretable in a way that yielded sensible groupings of public topic themes.
- Hierarchical Clustering- We supplemented LDA with hierarchical clustering in a document-term matrix to enable us to see how the groupings of Reddit postings were related. The resulting dendrograms revealed how the discussion threads joined up at different levels of similarity to enable us to uncover larger groupings outside of topic modeling.

A. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) – ICE Raids Dataset

We conducted topic modeling, coherence assessment, and clustering on the ICE raids data to reveal conversation themes and organization. LDA Topic Modeling identified 12 topics. Prominent among these are

- Topic 4: Closely related to ICE arrests, agents, and raids
- Topic 1: Conversations about jobs and workers.
- Topic 11: Immigration policy and deportation.

Other subjects are associated with geopolitics, political parties and race issues as shown in Fig 1.

Fig. 1. Topic Modeling for ICE Raids.

Coherence Score Analysis was utilized to determine the best number of topics. There was a maximum coherence score (0.625) for 5 topics which reflected the highest interpretable themes as shown in Fig 2.

Hierarchical Clustering visualized topic relationships. It clustered similar topics such as deportation, employment, and enforcement by ICE in a group, whereas geopolitical topics formed separate branches as shown in Fig 3.

B. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) – LGBTQ+ Dataset

We examined Reddit conversations on the topic of LGBTQ+ through topic modeling, coherence evaluation, and clustering. Topic Modeling (LDA) found 12 main topics, which are:

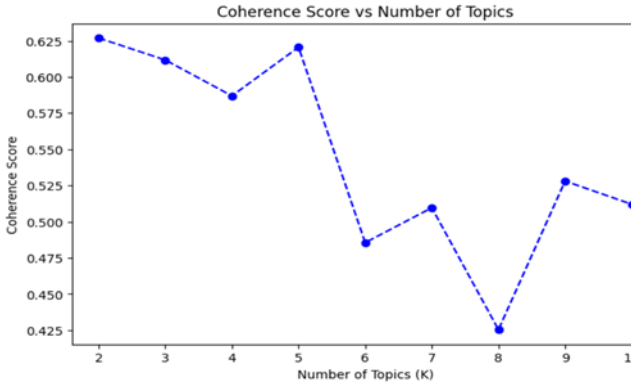

Fig. 2. Coherence Score for ICE Raids.

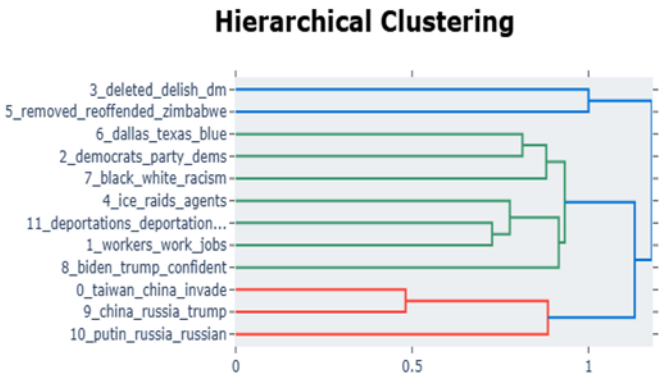

Fig. 3. Hierarchical Clustering for ICE Raids.

- Topic 8 & 9: Both centered on gay, trans, and gender identity themes.
- Topic 2: Family and school-based dialogue (teachers, parents, students).
- Topic 7 & 10: Fascism references & political tensions and debates

Coherence Score analysis showed maximum coherence (0.54) at 3 topics to help in the identification of the most interpretable topic configuration as shown in Fig 5.

Hierarchical Clustering grouped topics into branches that encompass gender identity, legal/policy issues, economic considerations, and political disputesas shown in Fig 6.

These results illustrate the multifaceted nature of LGBTQ+ dialogue that involves identity on a personal level, education, politics, and social justice themes.

C. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) for Birthright Citizenship Dataset

We explored reddit discussions on birthright citizenship using topic modeling, coherence scoring, and clustering. Topic Modeling (LDA) identified 12 topics, which are

Fig. 4. Topic Modeling for LGBTQ+ rights.

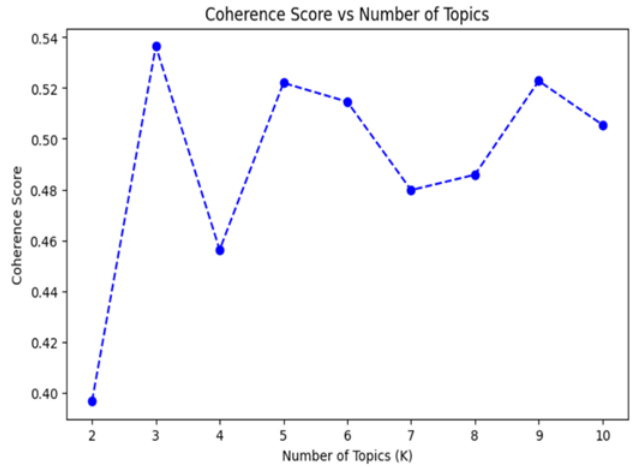

Fig. 5. Coherence Score for LGBTQ+ rights.

- Topic 4: Focused on birthright citizenship and the constitution.
- Topic 6: Regarding protests and citizenship participation.
- Topic 7: Included abortion and Roe v. Wade citations.
- Topic 10: Explored visas for parents and temporary citizenship.

Coherence Score analysis found maximum coherence (0.58) at 2 topics that led to the optimal topic numbers as shown in Fig 9.

Hierarchical Clustering grouped the conversations into clusters related to legal frameworks, protest, immigration status, and broader constitutional disputes as shown in Fig 10.

These results demonstrate that birthright citizenship controversies move beyond the borders of immigration to address legal, social, and political aspects.

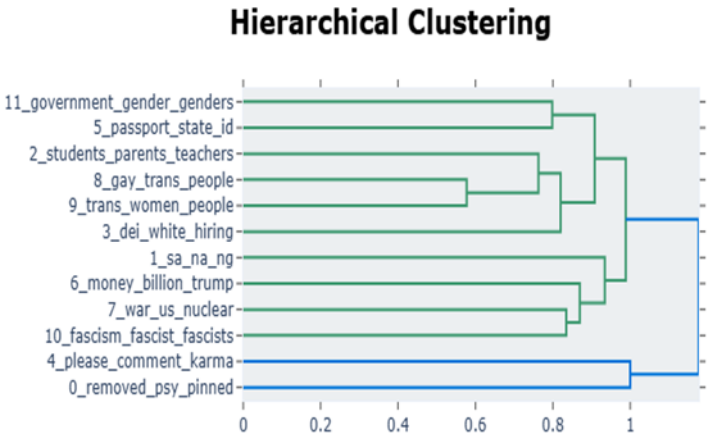

Fig. 6. Hierarchical Clustering for LGBTQ+ rights.

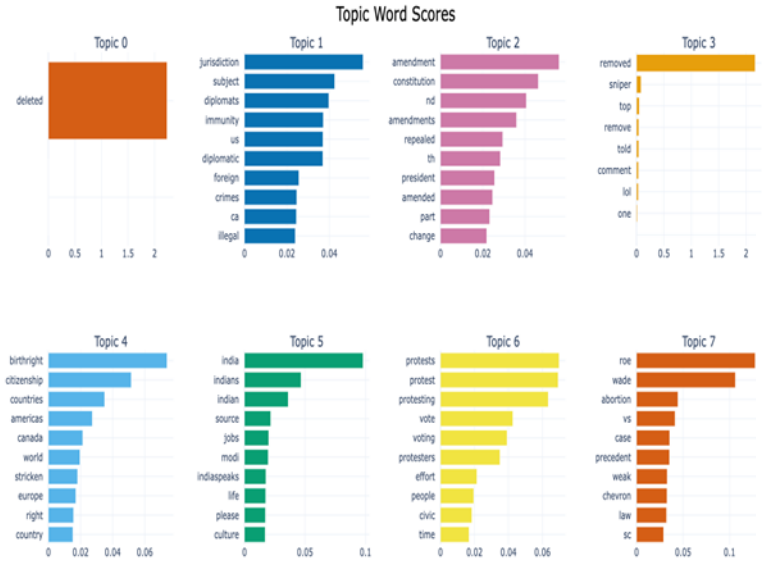

Fig. 7. Topic Modeling for Birthright Citizenship.

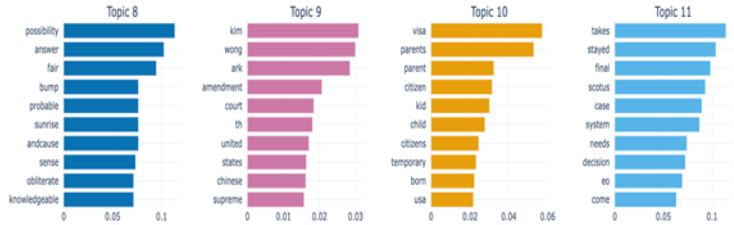

Fig. 8. Topic Modeling for Birthright Citizenship.

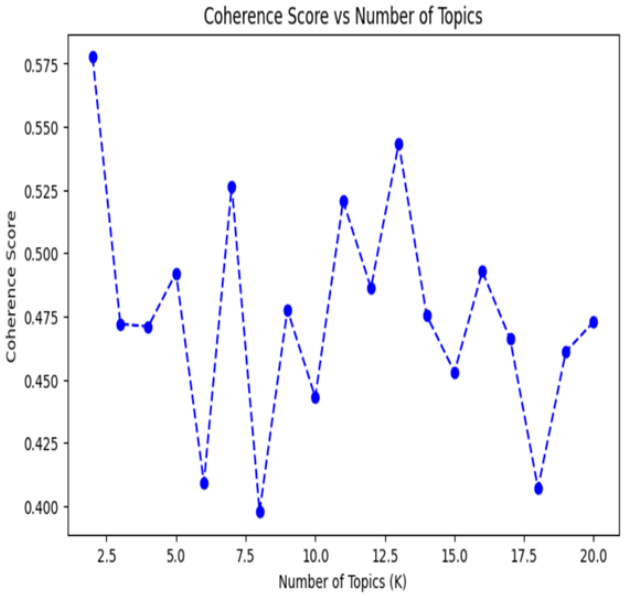

Fig. 9. Coherence Score for Birthright Citizenship.

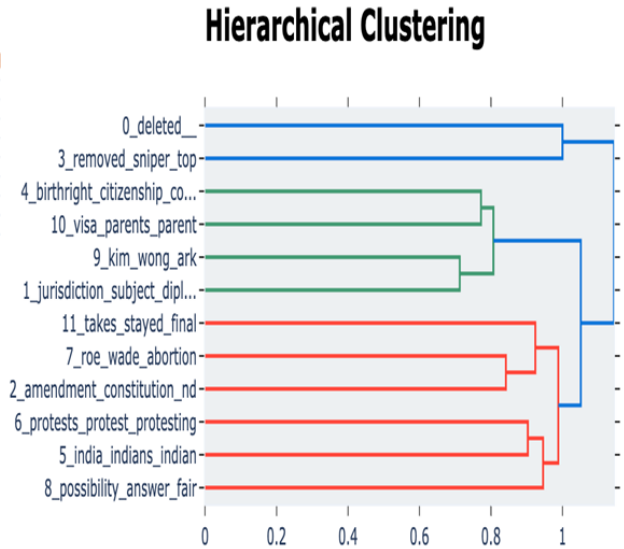

Fig. 10. Hierarchical Clustering for Birthright Citizenship.

D. Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA) – Tariffs Dataset

We analyzed Reddit discussions about tariffs using modeling, coherence scoring, and clustering. Topic Mod (LDA) identified 12 major topics that consist of

- Topic 4: Focus on trade policies and tariffs.
- Topic 0: Oil, crude, and refinery discourses.
- Topic 10: Stock market and investment volatility.
- Topic 11: Farming and agricultural influences.

Fig. 11. Topic Modeling for Tarrifs.

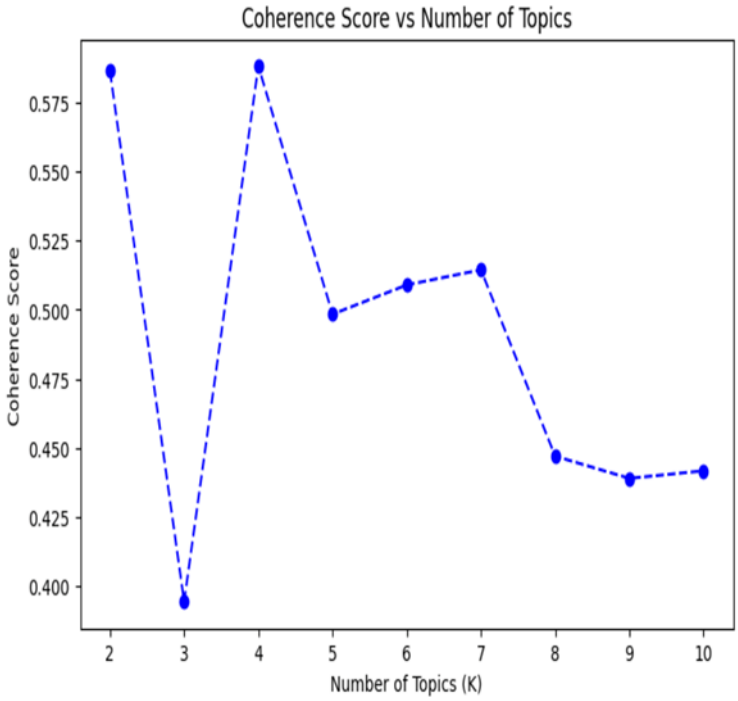

Fig. 13. Coherence Score for Tarrifs.

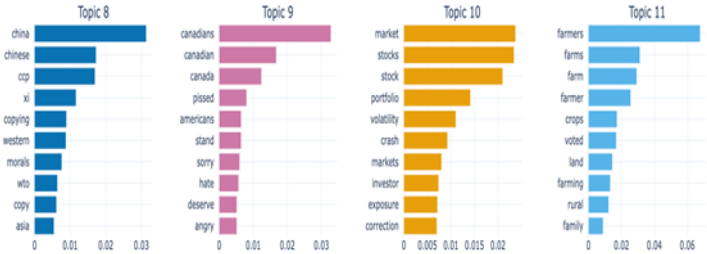

Fig. 12. Topic Modeling for Tarrifs.

Analysis of the coherence score revealed optimal coherence (0.58) at 2 and 4 topics and guided us to balance interpretability and topic richness as shown in Fig 13.

Hierarchical Clustering categorized conversations into themes of the economic sectors (oil, markets, farming), political approaches, and geopolitical topics (China, Canada) as shown in Fig 14.

They indicate the extent to which tariff-related debates range from their economic effects to political and foreign policy considerations.

VI. Data Analytics

To determine sentiment in Reddit postings about Trump's 2025 policies, we used two advanced natural language processing models as shown in Fig 15.

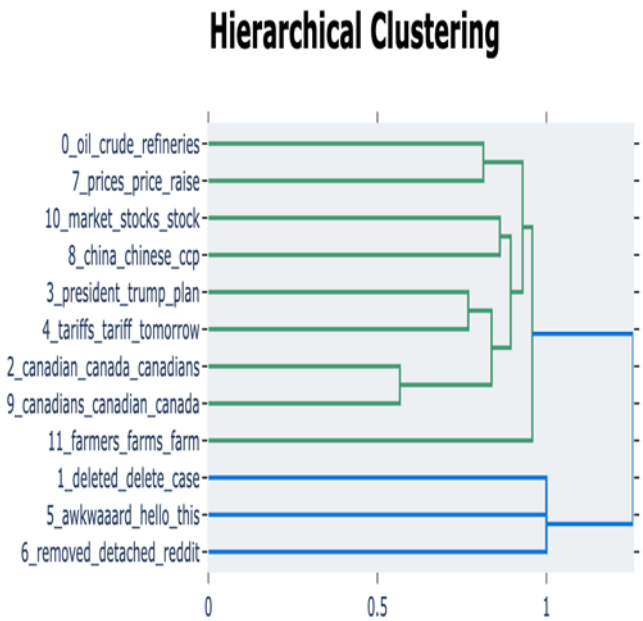

Fig. 14. Hierarchical Clustering for Tarrifs.

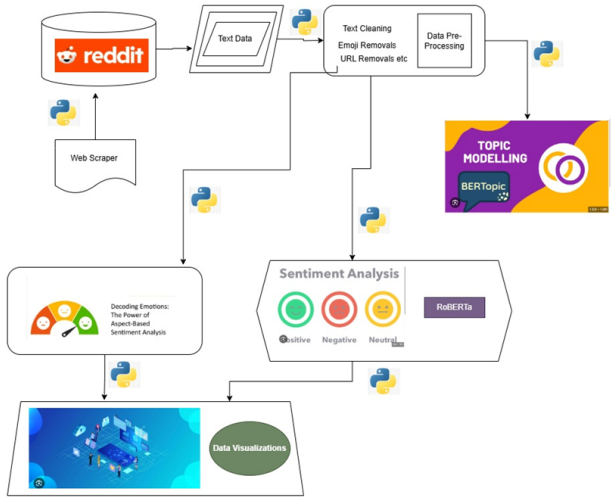

Fig. 15. Flow Chart of Project

A. Sentiment analysis using RoBERTa

- We employed the RoBERTa-base language model, a powerful transformer-based language model released by Facebook AI.
- RoBERTa advances the BERT algorithm to better extract deep contextual relationships in text through the use of a larger corpus for training and tuned hyperparameters.
- In particular, we used the roberta-base fine-tuned on sentiment analysis tasks (e.g., SST-2) to predict Reddit comments as positive, negative, or neutral.
- It works through tokenization of the input text, generating context embeddings through multiple attention layers and producing class probabilities.
- We chose the use of RoBERTa due to its exceptional performance in processing informal Internet language, slang, sarcasm, and political conversations as opposed to the standard use of machine learning.

B. Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA)

- We utilized Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA), using pre-split datasets and aspect-centric sentiment scoring for fine-grained sentiment analysis.
- In contrast to a prompt-based methodology, we segmented the data by topic theme (i.e., ICE raids, LGBTQ+ rights, tariffs, citizenship) and performed sentiment classification within each theme group.
- This enabled us to spot sentiment patterns not only overall, but also for each major policy domain, to uncover which topics elicited stronger positive, negative, or neutral responses.
- We used transformer-based models like RoBERTa to perform the sentiment scoring as they perform well on social and political language.
- This approach provided us aspect-level insights without the need to create customized user prompts or retraining the models, which made the workflow efficient and ideally suited for our large-scale Reddit datasets.
- We built a highly detailed and multifaceted analysis of public reaction to observe not only the overall positivity or negativity but also the specific areas or measures that caused the biggest emotional reactions.

VII. Data Visualization and Results Report

A. Sentiment Analysis on ICE RAIDS Dataset using RoBERTa

We graphed the sentiment analysis of the results of the ICE raids data in a series of bar and pie charts in order to depict the opinion trend. Out of all the Reddit comments for which we have conducted analysis, the graph indicated that there were approximately 4,300 that were classified as being neutral, approximately 3,200 that were negative, and slightly over 400 that were positive. There weren't any that was in the error category, indicating that the processing was exceptional.

When we examined the proportionate share through the pie chart, we observed that 53.5% of the comments conveyed a neutral sentiment, 42.1% negative sentiment, and a mere 4.4% positive sentiment as shown in Fig 16.

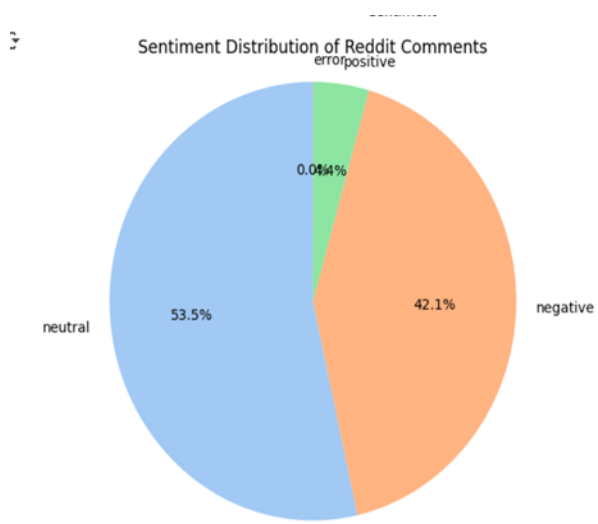

Fig. 16. Pie Chart of RoBERTa for ICE RAIDS.

B. Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) on ICE Raids

Aspect-based sentiment analysis (ABSA) was tested on two important aspects within the ICE raids data: "ICE" and "raid."

And for the ICE side of it, there were approximately 5,000 negative Reddit comments, 2,300 that were neutral, and only 700 positive. This amounted to about 62.9% negative, 28.4% that was neutral, and 8.7% that was positive in sentiment as shown in Fig 17.

Likewise for the raid component, there were about 5,300 negative, 2,100 neutral, and 600 positive comments, a split of 67.4% negative, 26.1% neutral, and 6.5% positive as shown in Fig 18.

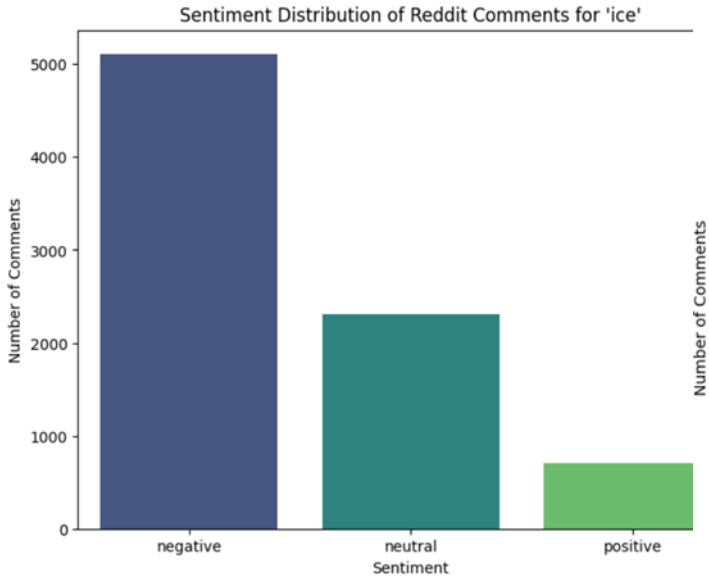

Fig. 17. Bar Chart of ABSA for Aspect ICE.

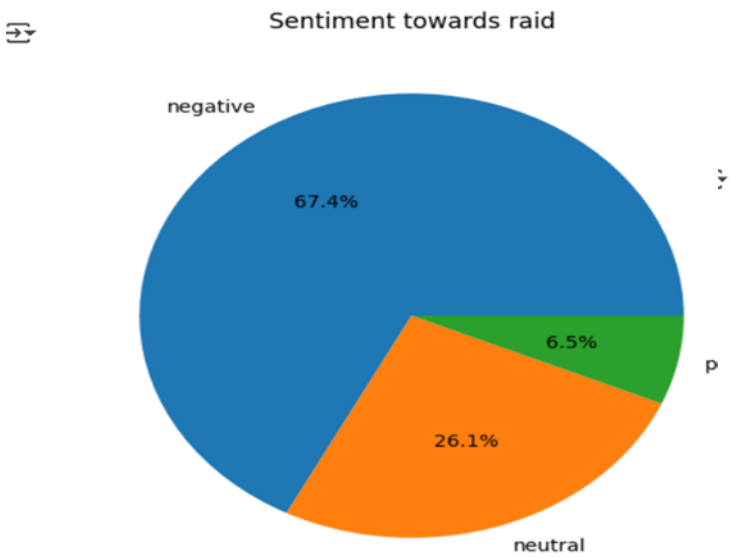

Fig. 18. Pie Chart of ABSA for Aspect RAID.

Overall, the results reveal that sentiment toward both IC and raids is overwhelmingly negative, reflecting widespread public criticism of immigration enforcement actions.

C. Sentiment Analysis on LGBTQ+ Dataset using RoBERTa

Sentiment analysis through the application of the use of the RoBERTa model on the corpus of the identified LGBTQ+ found that most of the Reddit comments made were negative (2,900), followed by a substantial quantity of negative ones (1,750), and a lesser proportion of positive ones (300) as shown in Fig 19.

In proportion, when visualized, the distribution was approximately 58.6% for the neutrals, 35.3% for the negative ones,

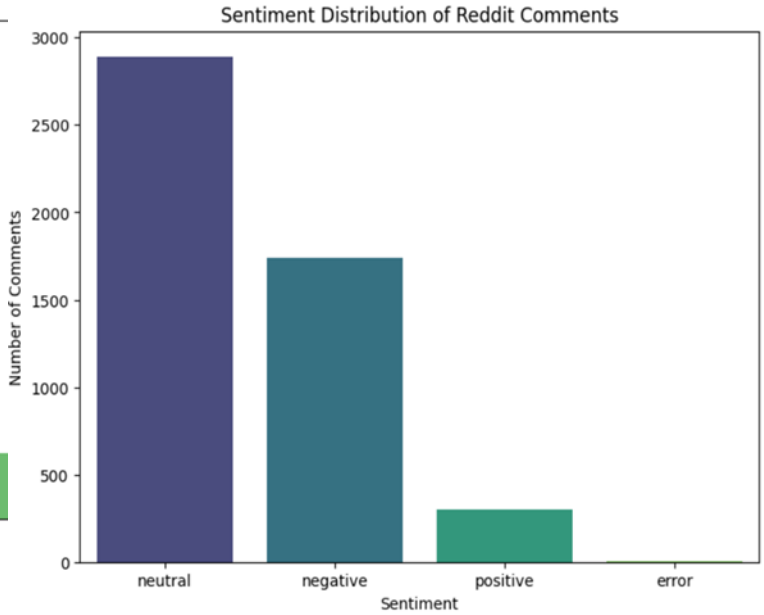

Fig. 19. Sentiment Analysis Distribution of Reddit Comments on LGBTQ+ Dataset

and 6.0% for the positive as shown in Fig 20.

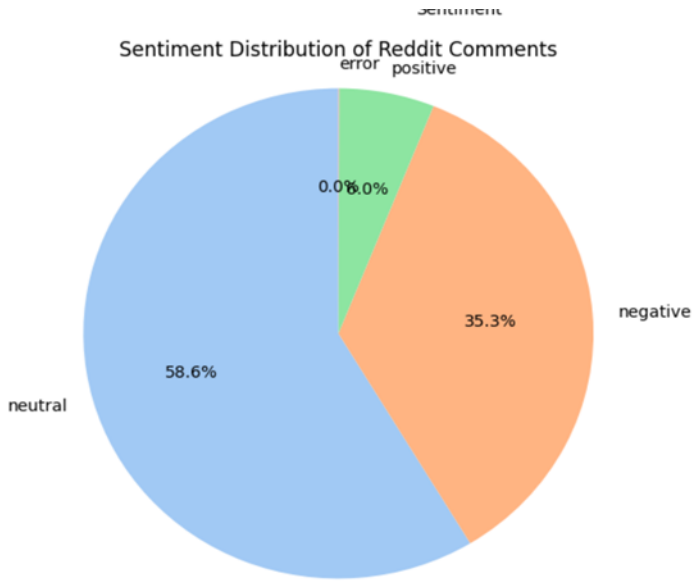

Fig. 20. Sentimen Distribution of Reddit Comments on LGBTQ+ Dataset

These results demonstrate that discussions about LGBTQ+ on Reddit went in the direction of negative observation or reporting of information and comprised a high rate of negative opinions in comparison to a low rate that was positive or supportive.

D. Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) on LGBTQ+ Dataset

Aspect-based sentiment analysis (ABSA) of the LGBTQ+ data was conducted on the two major aspects of “discrimina-

tion" and "sex".

For 'discrimination', there was a predominantly negative tone as 81.6% of the postings contained negative comments, 10.5% contained neutral comments, and 7.9% contained positive comments as shown in Fig 21.

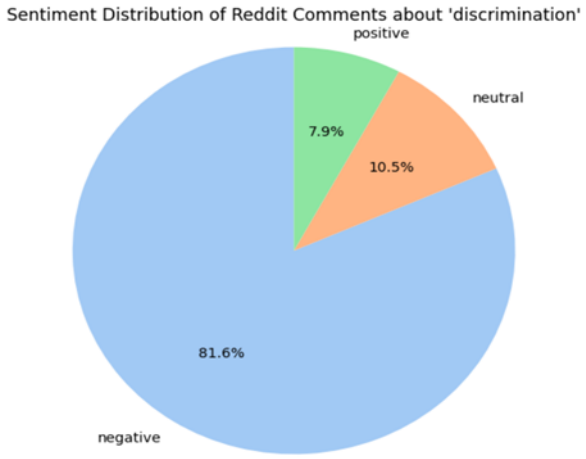

Fig. 21. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect Discrimination.

For discussion of a 'sex' nature, there was about 72.3% that was negative, 19.1% that was neutral, and 8.6% positive, of which the majority expressed critical or negative tones as shown in Fig 22.

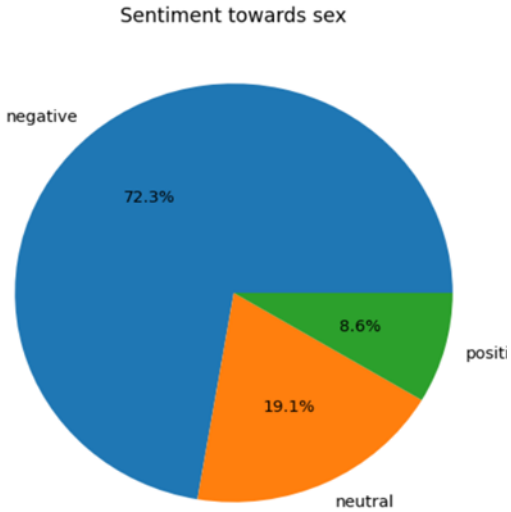

Fig. 22. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect Sex.

In the main, the ABSA results reveal that Reddit posts the LGBTQ+ generally have strong negative sentiment when the topic enters the realm of discrimination or sexuality, highlighting deep-rooted underlying social tensions and polarized views.

E. Sentiment Analysis on Tarrifs Dataset using RoBERTa

The RoBERTa sentiment analysis of the tariffs data revealed that the largest proportion of Reddit comments were neutral (21,000), followed by negative (14,500), and a lesser proportion of positive (2,500) as shown Fig 23.

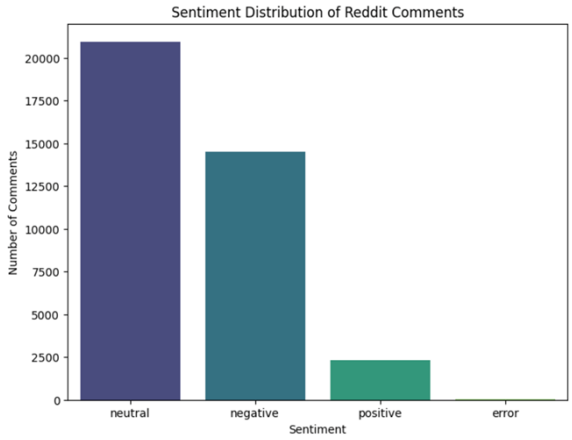

Fig. 23. Sentiment Analysis Distribution of Reddit Comments on Tariffs Dataset

When proportionally visualised, the data reflected about 65.9% negative and 34.1% positive distribution of emotions indicating a clear leaning towards dissatisfaction or concern in the public discourse about the topic of tariffs as well as trade policy as shown in Fig 24.

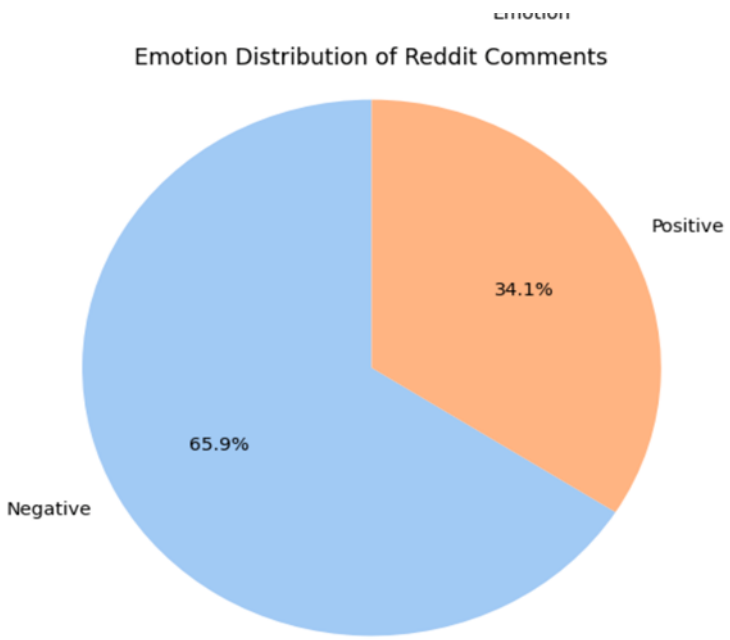

Fig. 24. Emotion Distribution of Reddit Comments on Tarrifs Dataset

These indicate that although the overwhelming majority of the comments remained neutral, of emotionally charged ones the sentiment was strongly negative and reflected public frustration or skepticism about tariff-related economic policy.

F. Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) on Tariffs Datas

The aspect-based sentiment analysis (ABSA) was train to concentrate on the specific "tariffs" aspect of Reddit cor ments.

The results showed that 68.2% of the tweets express negative sentiment about the tariffs, 21.2% expressed neut sentiment, and 10.6% expressed positive sentiment as show in Fig 25.

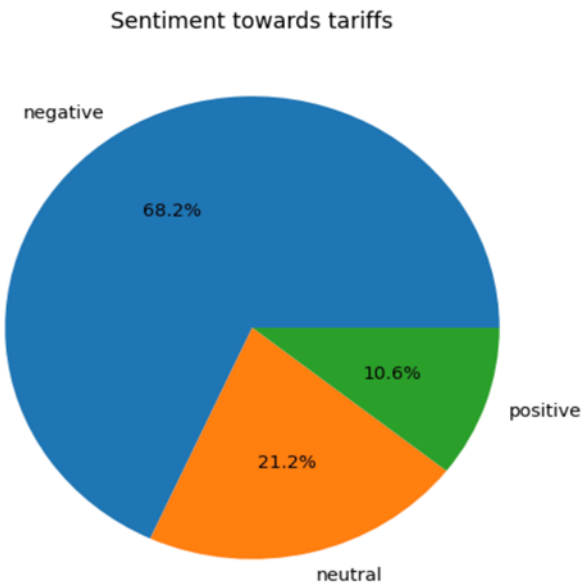

Fig. 25. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect Tarrifs.

This negative majoritarian sentiment encompasses force public criticism or displeasure for tariff policy that enco passes fear of economic impact considerations, commer relationships, and the performance of the policy, but in wh there is a small but supportive or positive opinion camp.

G. Sentiment Analysis on Birthright Citizenship Dataset us RoBERTa

The sentiment analysis by the RoBERTa of Reddit comments about birthright citizenship showed that most were neutral (3,100), followed by negative (1,600), and a lesser proportion positive (300) as shown in Fig 26.

Emotionally, the data we saw was about 63.9% negative and 36.1% positive, still strongly skewed to the negative side even after a very large chunk in the middle that was neutral as shown in Fig 27.

These findings indicate that although the users wrote about birthright citizenship in factual or unemotional tones to a considerable extent, an overwhelming number of emotionally charged statements reflected dissatisfaction, concern, or criticism towards this controversial political issue.

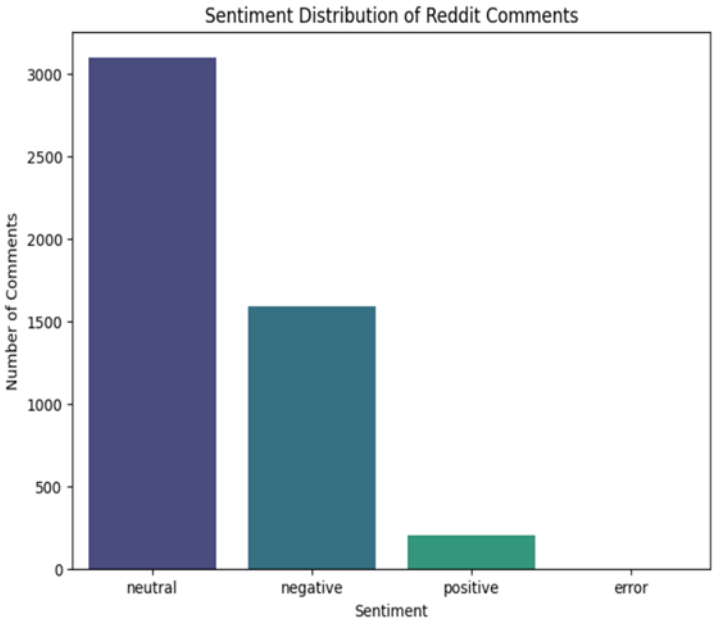

Fig. 26. Sentiment Analysis Distribution of Reddit Comments on Birthright Citizenship Dataset

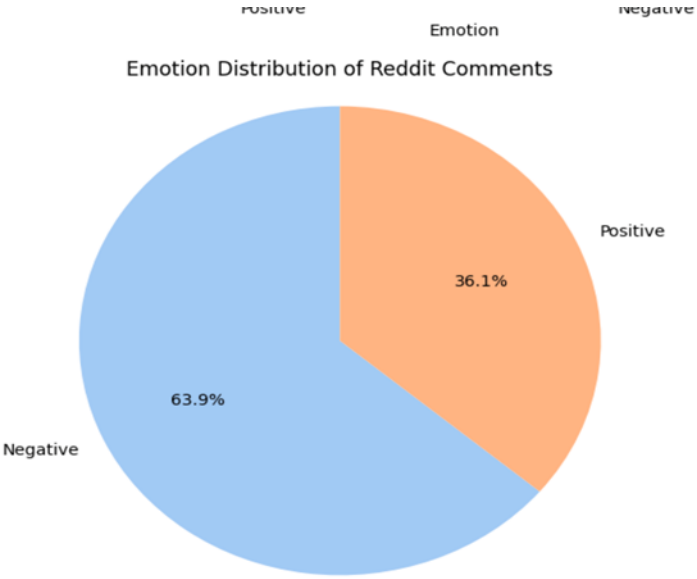

Fig. 27. Emotion Distribution of Reddit Comments on Birthright Citizenship Dataset

H. Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) on Birthright Citizenship Dataset

The aspect-based sentiment analysis of birthright citizenship encompassed a range of important aspects including government, citizenship, rights, and immigration.

For government, negative comments accounted for 70.1%, 22.5% were neutral, and a mere 7 as shown in Fig 28.

For citizenship, 62.1% were negative, 29.4% neutral, and 8.5% positive as shown in Fig 29.

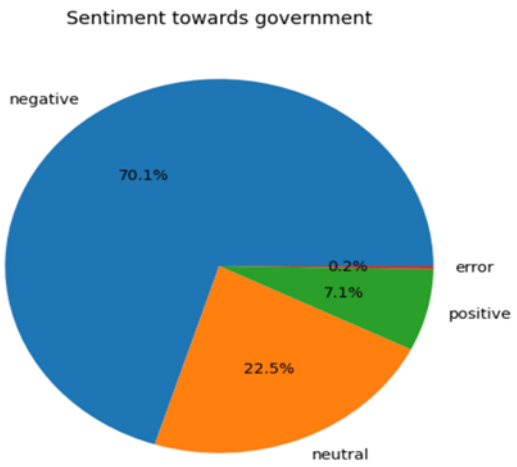

Fig. 28. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect 'government'.

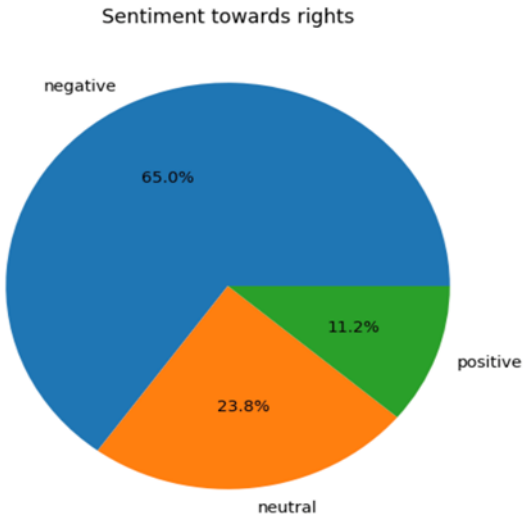

Fig. 30. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect 'rights'.

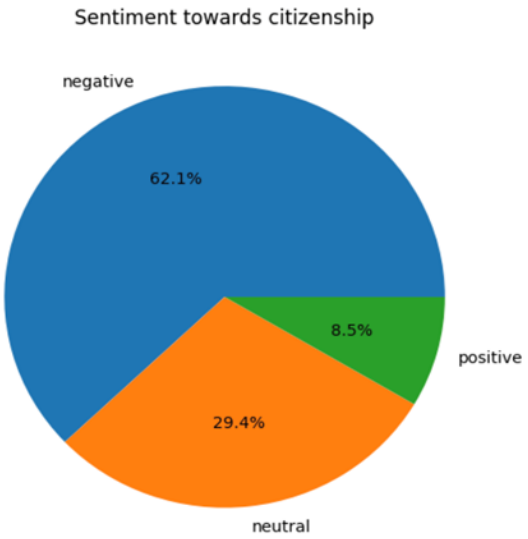

Fig. 29. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect 'citizenship'.

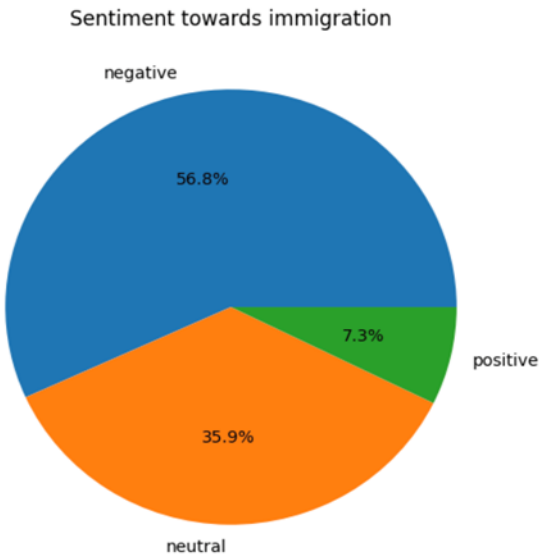

Fig. 31. ABSA of Reddit comments for Aspect 'immigration'.

For rights, 65.0% were negative, 23.8% neutral, and 11.2% positive as shown in Fig 30.

For immigration, 56.8% were negative, 35.9% neutral, and 7.3% positive as shown in Fig 31.

On the whole, the ABSA results indicate a prevailing negative opinion on all topics, showing concern and criticism of government policy, the rights of citizenship, and immigration by the public, only a minor proportion having a positive opinion.

VIII. Conclusion

This project, "Sympathy Over Polarization: A Computational Discourse Analysis of Trump's 2025 Policies," examined Reddit sentiment towards primary political issues through the use of RoBERTa and ABSA approaches. In the areas of ICE raids, LGBTQ+ rights, tariffs, and birthright citizenship, findings uniformly indicated prevailing negative sentiment that reflected intense public criticism and concern.

This analysis illustrates how computational techniques provide insightful information about public opinion that goes beyond information about overall sentiment to indicate specific emotional responses to certain aspects. These results support the use of sentiment and aspect analysis to enhance understanding of the complexities of this political discourse in the digital space

IX. Future Work

Building on our national-level analysis, we plan to:

- **State-level Sentiment and Forecasting:** Collect and ana- Analyze Reddit data segregated by U.S. state and compare sentiment-driven expectations versus each state's reality majority vote to assess regional accuracy.
- **External Validation through Polls:**Match our website-projected figures derived from conventional sources—TV exit polls Survey polls (e.g., Gallup, Pew), and debate response analyses—to measure how well social-media sentiment tracks polling trends.
- **Difference-in-Differences (DID) Analysis:** : Leverage DID methods to monitor changes in policy attitudes prior to and following important events (e.g., debate evenings, policy announcements), isolating treatment effects across different states or demographic groups.
- **Real-Time Dashboard:** Create an interactive state- live updating sentiment forecast level dashboard overlays polling data, and marks where digital and conventional metrics diverge

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